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Wolof co-operative work groups

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There are a number of reasons why group work is efficient and productive. Working with one's companions, joking and singing, is obviously less tedious than solitary labor. Singing and drums are important; in fact, drumming is so important that the work group of Njau village was inactivated for several months when the best drummer in the community was in mourning for a close relative. Working rhythmically to the beat of the drums, the stifling heat, the dust, and the monotony are minimized.

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Perhaps more important in stimulating production is competition between the workers. As elsewhere in West Africa,³ the Wolof co-operative work group involves dramatic competition when a large group of young men weeds a millet field for its chief. This occasion is considered a sort of sporting contest, attended by the community as a whole and preceded for several nights by a ceremony called *wongo* held in the village square. This ceremony formerly preceded battles, which have been replaced by working contests.

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Accompanied by drums, each young man paces back and forth in a dignified manner within a circle formed by the villagers, holding in one hand a long stick which, it is said, has replaced the spear of former days. He boasts of the work he will do on the chief's field, no doubt much as in former times he

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would have boasted of how well he would fight in battle. Placing the "spear" on the drum to silence it, he declares, "Tomorrow I will be among the young men like a lion when he enters a herd of cows," or "Tomorrow I will work from dawn to sunset without tiring," or "If anyone likes to drink sweat like water, he should come tomorrow and get it off my back." Young men often represent themselves as brave and strong, "like a lion," and try to live up to their boasts.

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The elders, small boys, and girl friends of the young men turn out to watch the contest. Groups from several villages are ranged on all sides of the field, and their members work furiously without stopping in a narrowing circle until they converge in the center. Young women sing praise songs for their favorites and fan them with their wrap-around skirts. If part of the circular line lags, girls and drummers stand behind the laggards and urge them to work faster. Each group has its own cheerleader or praiser, who encourages his group to work harder.

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The best worker is given a large hock from the cow butchered by the chief, and often also money, clothing, or some other gift. Such a champion is highly regarded in the community and usually has little difficulty in marrying the girl of his choice if she is a member of his social class. Since prestige attaches to hard workers in most agrarian societies, it is not surprising to find that hard work is part of the threefold behavioral ideal of the Wolof, along with religious piety and respect for one's elders.

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³ Melville J. Herskovits, *Economic Anthropology* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1952), p. 108.

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